



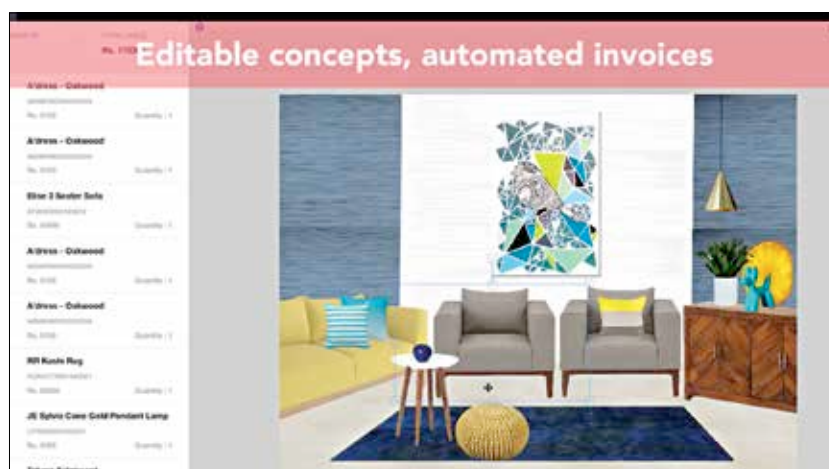
Computers advise farmers

A new computer model, SimSoy can advise farmers and seedmakers about what crops to plant and when by using algorithms. <https://digit.in/simsoy>



Make your own smart gadget

Google's AIY kits allows you to make programmable cameras to track objects and faces with artificial intelligence. <https://digit.in/aiykits>



Canvas from Livspace offers a single platform for the customers and the designers to get everything done for the entire lifecycle of the project

All of this happens in a simple web based tool that does not require any specialised knowledge apart from a basic knowhow of how drag-n-drop design tools work. Work that earlier required them to hire someone with an expertise in tools such as AutoCAD or 3DS Max can now be done by designers themselves - with the added benefit of being able to order the whole thing with one click.

This makes the job of the designer easier as well as they have one interface to deal with all the information and assets around. According to Livspace, design partners have reported as much as a 600 percent increase in productivity merely by using Canvas. There is a reason why companies like Urban Ladder have invested in creating their own designer networks and platforms as well.

CUSTOMER ADVANTAGE

On the other side of things, the customer also stands to gain. For starters, a lot more work goes into understanding what they want through a transparent process that has been standardised. They have one interface to deal with and an entire catalogue of products to express their taste. Additionally, while brands like Furdo are restricted to doing entire apartments at the moment, Livspace and certain competitors also accept projects restricted to certain parts of the home.

The aspect that has advanced the most here is the visualisation. Once reliant on paper blueprints and the likes, today, there's an entire array of tech to help them picture their house exactly how they want it to be.

Even the most basic visualisation involves 3D mockups of the proposed design. Quite a few companies like Furdo and Livspace also provide a 3D walkthrough that the customer can explore at their locations. Startups like Livspace, HomeLane, Furdo and established players like Urban Ladder are putting virtual reality simulations to use in their effort to give their customers a realistic experience of their designs.

Livspace's VR walkthrough, powered by an HTC Vive and designed by a dedicated team of more than 50 members, lets you walk around the house like you normally would. While there are some kinks yet to be figured out in terms of fidelity and interactivity of such simulations (you can't really open a cupboard or turn on



Livspace offers VR walkthroughs at their design centres.

the fan), it brings customers as close as they can get to their dream home before they commit financially. Another interesting use case comes from Urban Ladder in their virtual cataloguing efforts. Their in-store setup of VirtUL, their virtual reality catalogue, lets people browse through product categories, change material and colour, and walk around an infinite VR store. While their Living Spaces app and the Mood Board section on the existing Urban Ladder app could use some work, the Oculus Rift powered VirtUL makes up for both.

WHERE IT IS HEADED

In the near future, basic VR experiences will be shipped to customers which they'll be able to experience on smartphone-powered VR headsets - the likes of Google Cardboard and GearVR. Additionally, the entire sup-



VirtUL, available at Urban Ladder stores, lets you experience their catalog in VR

ply chain management system is being reworked by multiple players to cater to commercial projects down the line.

A lot of focus is also being put into quality control. Furdo intends to set up model factories where vendors can come and experience what the ideal manufacturing process should be like. Some players are also investing into setting up training organisations for skilled labour. According to Livspace, the market size is expected to jump to USD 35B in the next 3 years with approximately 4-5 percent of the overall market is poised to move online within the next 2 years. Without a doubt there is going to be a lot of activity in the near future amid home furnishing and interior design startups when it comes to bringing you and your dream homes together. 